

# INTERNATIONAL news

## US imposes 25% tariff on AI chips

The United States has imposed a 25% tariff on advanced AI chips, effective from January 15, 2026, under Section 232 of the National Security Act. Targeting Nvidia's H200 and AMD's MI325X, it aims to shift packaging and fabrication from Taiwan. The move drew measured support from US semiconductor firms. Nvidia welcomed the policy, citing support for domestic manufacturing, though industry groups warned of supply chain risks and higher prices.

## Trump unveils \$12 billion rare earths reserve to cut China's reliance

US President Donald Trump has announced Project Vault, a \$12 billion plan to build a strategic reserve of critical minerals, combining \$10 billion in Export-Import Bank loans with \$1.67 billion in private investment. Backed by firms such as GM, Boeing, and Google, the reserve aims to shield manufacturers from supply shocks and reduce reliance on China.

## SpaceX eyes \$50 billion IPO and merges with xAI

Elon Musk's SpaceX is preparing a mid-June 2026 IPO that could raise \$50 billion at a \$1.5 trillion valuation, rivalling Saudi Aramco's record listing. Investor interest is surging as Starlink drives growth. SpaceX has merged with Musk's AI startup xAI in a \$1.25 trillion deal, reorganising management ahead of one of history's largest flotations.

## Texas Instruments to buy Silicon Labs for \$7.5 billion

Texas Instruments (TI) will acquire Silicon Labs in an all-cash \$7.5 billion deal, closing in H1 2027 pending approvals. This strengthens TI's embedded processing and wireless connectivity, shifting Silicon Labs' production to US facilities. Expected synergies of \$450 million within three years, plus engineering depth, bolster TI's domestic manufacturing expansion and long-term technology leadership.

## Micron buys Powerchip's Taiwan fab for \$1.8 billion

Micron Technology will acquire Powerchip Semiconductor's P5 fabrication plant in Taiwan for \$1.8 billion in cash, with the deal expected to close by Q2 2026 pending approvals. The purchase expands Micron's DRAM wafer capacity by adding 27,870 square metres (300,000 square feet) of cleanroom space and establishes a long-term foundry partnership with Powerchip for advanced packaging.

## Micron plans \$24 billion memory chip plant in Singapore

Micron Technology is set to invest \$24 billion to build a memory manufacturing plant in Singapore, expanding output amid a global AI-driven chip shortage. The 65,032 square metre (700,000 square feet) wafer facility begins production in late 2028, focused on NAND for data centres and AI. Analysts warn shortages may persist until 2027, with SSD prices rising sharply.

## Portugal's Lithium Energy secures \$210 million grant for lithium refinery

Portugal's Lithium Energy has bagged a \$210 million EU grant to build a lithium refinery in Estarreja, starting operations by 2030. With 50,000-tonne annual capacity, it could power two million EVs. Backed by Jose de Mello and Bondalti, the project strengthens Europe's battery supply chain amid rising demand and reduced reliance on Chinese imports.

## Canada to slash tariffs on Chinese EVs

Canada and China have struck a trade deal cutting tariffs on up to 49,000 China-built EVs annually to 6.1%, down from 100%. Over half must be affordable models under CAD \$35,000 within five years. In return, Canada gains tariff relief on steel and aluminium, as well as expanded exports, boosting investment in the EV supply chain.

## Samsung reports 24% YoY rise in revenue and record profits in 4Q25

Samsung Electronics posted a 24% revenue surge to ₩93.8 trillion (\$65.6 billion) in Q4 2025, with operating profit tripling to ₩20.1 trillion, driven by memory chip shortages and AI server demand. Shares dipped after initial gains, as smartphone profits fell 9.5% year-on-year, though display earnings doubled and AI growth remains a focus.

## TSMC's profit jumps 35% in the fourth quarter of 2025

TSMC posted record Q4 2025 net profit of T\$505.7 billion (\$16 billion), up 35% year-on-year and above forecasts, driven by strong AI-related demand from Nvidia and Apple. Advanced nodes (3nm, 5nm, and 7nm) accounted for 77% of revenue. With capex set at \$52-56 billion, TSMC projects 30% revenue growth in 2026.

## Intel's fourth quarter 2025 revenue slips 4% despite AI push

Intel reported Q4 2025 revenue of \$13.7 billion, down 4% year-on-year, with a GAAP loss per share of \$0.12. The full-year revenue was \$52.9 billion, flat versus 2024. Its Data Center and AI segment revenue rose 9% to \$4.7 billion, offsetting PC weakness. Intel forecasts Q1 2026 revenue of \$11.7-12.7 billion.

## Apple buys Israeli startup Q.AI in major AI wearables push

Apple has acquired Israeli startup Q.AI for nearly \$2 billion, one of its largest deals, to accelerate the development of AI-powered wearables. Q.AI develops 'silent speech' tech interpreting facial and muscle movements for headphones and smart glasses. The move strengthens Apple's imaging and machine learning capabilities as rivals like Meta, Google and OpenAI race into AI wearables.

## Samsung set to ship HBM4 chips for Nvidia

Samsung is set to become the first supplier to mass-produce and ship HBM4 chips after the Lunar New Year, securing a mid-20% share of early demand. The chips will power Nvidia's next-gen Vera Rubin GPUs for generative AI. Shipments begin mid-February, with performance gains of 2.4 times over the prior generation, intensifying competition among memory makers.

## Nexperia fights for its control with its Chinese owner, Wingtech

Lawyers for Nexperia and its Chinese owner, Wingtech, clashed in Amsterdam over its control, disrupting supplies to carmakers. Judges may probe alleged mismanagement under suspended CEO Zhang Xuezheng. The conflict has paralysed operations, halted wafer shipments to China, and left Nexperia planning a \$260 million investment in Malaysia as state-backed management resists Wingtech.

## US and Taiwan strike trade deal with chips, and China is in focus

The US and Taiwan clinched a trade pact that cuts tariffs on semiconductors and many exports, while Taiwanese firms pledged \$250 billion in US investment, including \$100 billion from TSMC. The deal strengthens ties amid tensions with China, aiming to shift 40% of Taiwan's chip supply chain to America. Semiconductor shares rose as Washington prioritises chip security.

## Eastern European space startup secures €930,000 to power lunar missions

Latvian startup Deep Space Energy raised €930,000 in pre-seed funding, plus €580,000 in ESA, NATO DIANA and government contracts, to develop radioisotope-based power generators. The technology, five times more fuel-efficient than traditional RTGs, aims to boost satellite resilience and lunar missions. Applications span defence satellites and Artemis rovers, promising extended lifespans and major cost savings.